NIRMALA SITHARAMAN
Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

FIRM ON A HIGH GROWTH PATH

With India's rapidly changing position in the emerging global order and the strength of its economy a key theme at the India Today Conclave, who better than the country's finance minister to shine a light on the subject? It was Nirmala Sitharaman who kicked off the first session of the conclave, elaborating on the unfinished reforms on the government's agenda, which it will have to address with speed and purpose if it comes to power for a third term. Especially as the International Monetary Fund has projected that India could be a $6 trillion economy by 2028. How will India negotiate the continuing global uncertainties like the wars in Ukraine and Gaza that can impact the flow of foreign direct investment and trigger another round of inflation? How will the government ensure quality jobs for the millions who pass out of our educational institutions every year and address the widening gap between the rich and the poor? And while the several pandemic measures helped the economy recover quickly and, as the government claims, reduced poverty greatly, a lot still remains to be done. In an election year, the finance minister also kept up her criticism of the Opposition for issues that persist—be it our inability to proceed with land or agriculture reforms or provide enough jobs for our youth. ■

ON UNFINISHED REFORMS

THE KIND OF REFORMS WE NEED TO UNDERTAKE NOW WILL HAVE TO HAVE GREATER COORDINATION BETWEEN THE CENTRE, STATES AND THE URBAN LOCAL BODIES, PANCHAYATS AND SO ON. MOST STATES UNDERSTAND THAT IT BENEFITS THEM AS WELL, BUT MANY PROGRAMMES GET BLOCKED

ON FREEBIES

YOU (OPPOSITION-RULED STATES) DO NOT HAVE BUDGETARY SUPPORT FOR SOME FANTASTIC IDEA THAT YOU THROW ABOUT. AND THEN ONCE YOU GET THE VOTE, YOU DON'T HAVE MONEY TO FUND THAT... BUT YOU WANT THE CENTRE TO FUND YOU BECAUSE YOU HAD THESE FANCY BASKETS OF *REVDI*S GIVEN TO THE PEOPLE

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **The Opposition's hypocrisy is getting exposed and, in this election, people are seeing a government that delivers. If an environment is building up for the prime minister to come back, it's two-thirds on the back of the government's work and the vision with which it is functioning and at least a third because of those who have wasted Parliament's time**
- **If stocks are overvalued, we should let the markets play out. We should leave it to the wisdom of the markets because we have seen that despite huge fluctuations globally, Indian markets have maintained a certain level of sanity**
- **Shell or loss-making companies may indeed have bought the electoral bonds, something which will have to be looked into**

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH